

Indian market. If you ask me whether engineering graduates should immediately dive into it, I would say they should if they are passionate about their idea, and even though it might be risky," says Subramaniam, who founded Cosmic Circuits.

Ganesh Shankar says, "I personally think it is a good time to start your own business. One of the most important reasons is that, we now have fast computers available at low prices, and there are many software tools freely available online or at reasonable prices. Computer-aided development is the current trend, and anyone with a strong grasp of engineering fundamentals, good creativity and some training in software can potentially design any thing under the sun."

The pitfalls

Chaddha informs, "The biggest pitfall that I have observed is that students take their teachers too seriously. Most lecturers encourage students to settle for a job. If students take their education very seriously, this becomes their biggest hurdle. They must use their education for their own benefit and not merely to excel in terms of scoring high marks."

V. Sunder believes entrepreneurs need to take a lot of risks. He says, "There are pitfalls and problems along the way, and it helps to have mentors, who can, in some cases, help you avoid common mistakes." He adds, "But the biggest pitfall is surrounding oneself with the wrong people. The right people are those who are going to encourage you to keep going even if you feel like quitting." Another pitfall is to stop learning new skills once the start-up team has started attaining some level of success, informs Sunder. Learning new skills and building on already attained skills is important to stay relevant in the market.

Ganesh Shankar says, "One of the pitfalls an engineer falls into is trying to do all the work in-house. A start-up team should concentrate on its core strengths and do only what it can provide maximum value addition to;

the rest should be sub-contracted to various suppliers."

The current advantages

There are many advantages of setting up your own business in India, believes Subramaniam. He says, "First, there's a huge local market. Today, we are importing nearly all our electronics. So there's a huge opportunity in terms of the local market. India is also well-recognised internationally, with regard to technical skills." Sunder believes that today, with the power of social media and the Internet, it is possible to source funding or get across to an angel investor. He says, "Marketing and publicity can go viral, and reach out to millions or to a large customer base at a single go, which is a blessing."

Comparing the current situation to the time when Chaddha started his business in the 90s, he feels that there are plenty of advantages for engineers today. He says, "At that time, there were many hurdles. For instance, to get Adobe Acrobat Reader, I had to pay nearly ₹ 8000. Today, Adobe Reader comes free of cost. Another instance was when I bought my first compiler—I had to pay US\$ 4000. Today, if you go to Freescale's website, you can easily download its compiler free of cost." He adds, "Those days, I had to first convince my customer to believe in my ideas, and based on that I used to borrow money to execute them. Today, things are much cheaper. But on the flip side, since lots of engineers graduate every year, there is more competition. When I started my business in embedded electronics, there were very few people in the field because costs were pretty high. You needed at least US\$ 10,000 to start developing your own products. Today, Texas Instruments sells one of its kits for just \$ 5. Thank the Internet for the low-cost resources available today."

Chaddha informed that for his first design, however, he was able to get the development board and all related software on loan from Freescale

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